India under Nehru, therefore, embarked on the policy of non-alignment as she was keen to preserve her national interest by keeping away from either the Western capitalist bloc led by the United States or the Socialist bloc led by the Soviet Union. Nehru told the Constituent Assembly on 4 December 1947: “Whatever policy we may lay down, the art of conducting foreign affairs of a country lies in finding out what is most advantageous to the country. We may talk about international goodwill and mean what we say. But in the ultimate analysis government functions for the good of the country and no government dare do anything, which in the short or long run is manifestly to the disadvantage of the country”.[5]

Another major challenge faced by India was economic development. After independence, India faced the serious problem of poverty alleviation and for that she realized that dependence on both the blocs was necessary to spearhead India’s economic and industrial development. Nehru was quite realistic to recognize the economic strength that was central to the stability and social coherence of the country. Economic development would help to build up a strong India. Therefore, in March 1947, he stated in the Constituent Assembly, “if we had been some odd little nation in Asia or Europe it would not have mattered much, but because we counted and because we’re going to count more and more in the future, everything we do becomes a matter of comment and many people do not like our counting so much. It is not a question of our viewpoint or of attaching ourselves to this or that bloc, it is merely a fact that we are potentially a great nation and a big power and possibly it is not liked by some people that anything should happen to strengthen us”.

Simultaneously, Nehru rejected isolationism and he clearly stated that “ we maintain our old ties with those countries because no nation can live in isolation….That some people obsessed by passion and prejudice disapproved of our relations with the Anglo-American bloc is not sufficient reason for us to break any bond which is of advantage to us”. Thus, Nehru, despite vehement criticisms, forged the membership of the Commonwealth. He viewed that it did not compromise the country’s freedom in international affairs, but it acted as a shield against the reigning powers of the day.